Buying You Time (Waiting)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/61774705.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

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Bowdysseus, Bow Odysseus, Glimmer as Penelope, Pining, Married Glimbow, Glimbow Reunion, POV Glimmer (She-Ra), Queen Glimmer (She-Ra), King Bow, Inspired by EPIC: The Musical - Jorge Rivera-Herrans, Glimmer Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Happy Ending

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by ResFlower

Summary

She knows that the battle with Troy rages on. Knows that their allies need them. Still, she feels the bitterness drip from her bones. Why is rescuing Helen worth Glimmer being robbed of her husband for gods know how long? To give birth alone? To hold her child and know Bow will be missing moments and milestones they can never get back?

She doesn’t realize she's started crying until she feels Bow's and moving up and down her back rhythmically. It only makes her cry harder.

"I promise I'll be back." He whispers fiercely, his own voice coated in tears. "Nothing will keep me from you and our child."

"I will be waiting for you." She promises in return, hiding her face in the crook of his neck. She takes a deep breath, trying to commit the smell to memory. It's clean and comforting, and she could pick it out anywhere. "No matter how long it takes."

OR

While Bow is off to war, Glimmer is waiting. EPIC: the Musical AU.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Glimmer lets her hands run through Bow’s hair. There are some things about Bow that only she gets to see, and those are her favorite moments. The King of Ithaca is known for his cunning, his strategy, the wise hand he uses to rule. He isn't known for being soft, unguarded. But with Glimmer, he is.

His hands are on either side of her swollen belly, eyes caught on it as if he could peer inside, looking at the child growing within her womb.

His voice is a low rumble. "Once you're born, you'll have whatever your heart desires, princess." He presses his forehead above her navel, and she feels a kick flutter. Bow smiles like he's seeing the sun for the first time. "That's right."

"You'll spoil them rotten." Glimmer chides him breathlessly. "Besides, it could be a boy for all you know."

They'd been teasing each other since they discovered she was with child and carrying the heir to the throne. Bow insisted it would be a girl and Glimmer a boy, mostly for the banter of it.

Bow shrugs. "It makes no difference to me what they are, as long as they’re healthy and happy." He presses another kiss to her belly, somehow sweeter than the last. "And as for spoiled—it’s what they deserve.” His eyes drift down again. “I'd make the rain clouds cry for you, little one. If that's what you wanted."

"Don't over promise." A lump rises in her throat as she takes in her husband’s earnest expression. "Especially now."

Bow's smile dims and he nods softly. He gets off his knees, standing to his full height, all but towering over Glimmer, which admittedly isn’t a hard thing to do given her short frame. He was not the tallest or most muscle-bound man to court Glimmer, but that hardly mattered to her.

Some thought that as a princess of Sparta, she'd be impressed by pure brawn. Bow was different. He saw who she was, engaged

with her in conversation of intellect and politic that her other suitors either thought she wouldn't understand or didn't understand themselves. And he was so unbelievably gentle and kind, but still the greatest warrior Glimmer had ever seen, save perhaps her own father.

She doesn't know how she'll cope without him.

The look of desperation on Bow's face surely mirrors her own. "I tried everything to stay behind." He whispers, reaching out and pulling her into his embrace.

As if she didn't know that. Bow argued until he was blue in the face that he needed to stay in Ithaca, but the other Greek kings were unpersuaded. He even feigned madness to try and persuade them to leave him behind, but it didn't work.

She knows that the battle with Troy rages on. Knows that their allies need them. Still, she feels the bitterness drip from her bones. Why is rescuing Helen worth Glimmer being robbed of her husband for gods know how long? To give birth alone? To hold her child and know Bow will be missing moments and milestones they can never get back?

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"Hopefully it takes no time at all. We've sent our best men. I wouldn't be surprised if Troy falls before I even arrive." He whispers in her hair.

She lets out a short, harsh laugh. "That seems like wishful thinking, my King."

"I can stand to be wishful." He presses a soft kiss on her forehead. "I'll be carrying you with me."

"And the babe." She reminds him, pulling his hand to meet her belly again.

He gives her a reassuring squeeze. "Of course." He sighs before peeking down at her hopefully. "I won't be leaving today though. Perhaps we could retire early?"

"It's noon, Bow."

He might not be leaving today, but preparations are well on their way, stocking his ship where he and six hundred men will live as they make the voyage to Troy. She knows he has plenty to do to ensure their success.

He grins, raising one eyebrow. "I know." He reaches for her hand, intertwining their fingers. “I can spare a few hours for my wife.”

She tries to fight her smile. "You'd think our wedding bed is your favorite place in the world."

"I did build our palace around it." He reminds her of something she would never forget. “Our wedding bed is the very heart of our palace.”

She never could have imagined back then, the day she met a shy boy underneath an olive tree that one day that tree would become her wedding bed, carved by hand by that very same boy. She remembers how tirelessly Bow worked, leaving the trunk of the olive tree intact and not allowing another soul to even touch the wood it was made from. He’d promised that much like their marriage, their wedding bed, rooted to the ground, was permanent and everlasting.

"True." She sighs, shoving aside her nostalgia and grief. She'll have plenty of time to miss Bow when he isn't in front of her. "Let's go." She tugs on his hand, leading them back to the most sacred of places.

Glimmer wakes with a gasp, sitting up with her hands clutched in the sheets. She glances around the room blearily, everything slightly out of focus. After a few moments, her heart drops to her gut like a stone.

It's all the same. The other side of the bed is perfectly made, untouched by another body. Her womb is empty and she's much older than the memory-like dream she'd been ripped from.

She sighs, rubbing the sleep from her eyes. It had been a long night, once again unthreading all the work she'd done before on her shroud. Her back hurts from the years of weaving and taking apart the same piece of fabric.

Glimmer takes a moment after pulling on her robe to stop at her window. She can feel the grief wrapping around her lungs like an old friend, familiar and ever-present.

She's imagined Bow's ship on the horizon countless times, and once, a decade ago, she swore she saw it. There was a terrible, unnatural storm and suddenly the ship was gone, as if it was just another figment she conjured with her hope.

The terror only got worse at that point. Every day that passes her faith that she'll see her husband again grows dimmer and weaker. She still does what she can to buy time. If there's even the smallest chance that Bow will return, she must keep fighting for it. She knows that he won't give up, so she can't either.

Glimmer takes the servant's hallway to a private dining hall. It's not the main dining hall where her would be suitors spend most of their time, draining her resources as they lie in wait, with her as their desired prey.

She knows it isn't safe. She knows that any of those rats, given half the chance, would dishonor her in the most brutal way. Even if she wasn't holding out hope that Bow would return, she'd never marry them. She'd rather die.

"This is ridiculous." She hears her sister-in-law's voice before she sees her. Mermista's face is twisted in righteous anger, a familiar look from many of her visits. "I don't understand why the gods wont' smite the pigs making a mockery of your hospitality."

"I ask myself the same thing every day." Glimmer sits at the table, already tired. "It's good to see you, sister."

Mermista smiles, her eyes still tight with anger. "It's good to see you too, although I wish the circumstances different." She grabs an olive from the modest spread before them. "Where is my favorite nephew?"

"Your only nephew, and I haven't seen him today." Her son is a man now, a righteous one at that. She knows that his presence deters her suitors from worse behavior, and for that she is thankful. "I'm sure he'll come to see us when he hears that you are visiting."

Mermista only comes for a day or two every few months. She claims if left to her devices for too long she might do something to the suitors that would displease the gods. Glimmer can't say she blames her.

"Good." Mermista eyes her. "Are we sure he can't kick out the infestation that's taken residence in your palace? He *is* the heir."

Glimmer sighs, tired of this conversation that seems to run in a loop. "The only one who could do anything is the rightful King of Ithaca, and that is my husband." She reminds Mermista forcefully. "If any of us dishonor our guest, we threaten to turn the gods against us."

Her lips curl into a grimace. "And what have the gods—"

"Enough." Glimmer snaps, taking a sharp breath through her nose. "I know you're wiser than that."

To openly question the gods is to call for their ire. Glimmer has had those blasphemous thoughts before, but she quashes them. If there's any chance that Bow can make it home, she's not going to ruin it by daring the gods to keep him from her.

Mermista looks cowed, her gaze averted. "You're right. I want them home too, you know."

Glimmer bites her lip. "I know." Mermista's love is amongst the men who have filed to return from Troy, and Bow is her brother. She's suffering just like Glimmer is.

Mermista turns to look at her but there's a bright flash and the roll of thunder, the kind that makes hair stand on end with its force. Both women turn to look out the small window, the Ionian Sea stretched out before them with an almost purple hue, black clouds filling the sky to the point that they look like they are touching the ground.

She's never seen anything like this before. Except she has—just once. Glimmer all but runs to the opening, her eyes desperately searching for what she wishes to see. There's no ship—at least, none that she can make out in the unnatural crashing waves.

She's left waiting, eyes on the storm for as long as it's there. Where once there was a frightening storm of the kind Ithaca had never seen before, there's nothing but languid waters and bright skies. Same as last time.

"What *was* that?" She can't tell if Mermista is baffled or frightened. Maybe both.

"I don't know." Glimmer murmurs, eyes still off in the distance. The sun is beaming now, and hope blooms new in her chest.

Glimmer lays on her front, eyes closed as she tries to drift into sleep. She lets out a startled gasp when she feels a hand on her. For a moment she freezes up, fear striking her heart, until she hears a familiar voice shushing her. "It's me.”

She'd know Bow's voice any time, any place. "Really?"

It’s an unnecessary question. She knows the answer—this is a dream she's familiar with, one that she's had dozens of times over the years.

He ignores the question as she knew he would, his hand travels over her arm leaving a warm trail in its wake. "You've always been impossibly soft." His voice is wistful, but his fingers don't stop moving. "I'd do anything to touch you again."

"Aren't you?" She feels her skin pebble as if straining toward him. "Just don't stop."

She hears him sigh. She longs to see his face, but she doesn't want to jeopardize this. The few times she’s turned to catch a glimpse of him, she’s been jarred awake, remaining bereft. "I suppose so." His fingers move over her shoulders, then across her back. "Are you safe?"

"Safe enough." She doesn’t want to worry him, even this version of Bow that can't possibly be real. "I’ll be better if you stay." That much I true.

"Soon." He promises, but the weight of it slides right off her. It used to make her angry, these promises in her dreams. It reminds her of all the promises that remain unspoken for.

But now it's been too long, and this dream touch feels too close to Bow’s for her to let anything stand in the way of soaking up the attention. His hand stutters to a stop on the edge of her gown, as it always does.

His touch is always sweet and caring, but it grows more tentative every time this happens. Where once he touched her firmly, now

he moves as if trying to create a ghost of a touch instead of the concrete press of his skin that she so craves. It makes her worry, the change she notices in him. Even if it’s just a dream.

"I don’t deserve you." It’s a whispered confession, one that sounds so anguished she just knows its been rattling in his very soul for a long time.

She doesn't want to fight with him, but she can't let that stand. "That doesn't matter. You *have* me." Glimmer has spent much too long loving Bow to stop now.

"I'm afraid that won't be true if you know." His voice sounds choked, and the fear finds its way back into her blood stream.

"Know what?"

He's quiet and a second later she realizes he's gone. When Glimmer opens her eyes, it's to stare at her empty wedding bed, the once sacred place now a cage of loneliness she can't set herself free from.

She's left waiting again.

She tries to keep her hands from shaking as she stands on high, looking down at her supposed suitors. She clenches them on the banister, and she hopes nothing else will give her away.

"I have decided how I will choose my next husband." The words are bitter in her mouth, and she hates the roar from the crowd of suitors below, wailing and cheering in excitement.

She tries to hide her disgust from her expression. She can feel their eyes on her body, looks of lust and greed that feel slimy on her skin. It's a miracle she's made it this far, given that these men have no honor. She can see on their faces exactly what they'd like to do to her.

She holds up a piece of wood she's held dear since before she was married. "Whoever can string my husband's old bow and shoot through a dozen axes in one clean shot—he is the one who will sit on the throne by my side."

Another noisy roar from the crowd. Glimmer fights the urge to smirk.

Handing over her husband's preferred weapon is a small price to pay. This challenge is impossible to meet—she doubts one of these men can even string the bow, let alone make the shot she's tasked them with.

"Let your arrow fly when you know your aim is true." She offers advice that won't be heeded. "Only the best warrior can accomplish this. Best of luck."

Only Bow can do this. All the suitors will fail, bumbling about and injuring their pride. She looks forward to it. She steps away from the banister, giving her husband's bow to one of her remaining trusted servants. The suitors are already shoving each other below, arguing about who gets to try first.

Glimmer turns and leaves the room through one of the service hallways. She doesn't want to watch these men desecrate that bow like they've desecrated her palace. Instead of heading to her room, she takes a few turns until she's at a shrine. Athena's shrine used to be in a large room, but given that the palace is overrun, Glimmer had to make adjustments.

She'd always been partial to the goddess, even before she met her. The only times Athena appeared before Glimmer have been with Bow by her side. Now, she fears the goddess might be Bow's only hope to return home.

She lights an incense on the shrine then sits before it. "Athena. Please lend me your wisdom and guide me. I think that storm—I think there's a chance." She can't find the strength to vocalize her

deepest wish. "Whatever needs to be done, give me the strength to do it."

She knows that she's set to motion actions she can't take back. Her challenge is impossible, and the suitors are unpredictable. She doesn't know how they'll react when they realize that this is another delay, one they won't be able to overcome honestly.

Glimmer takes a deep breath, the smell of cedar and orange filling the air. She's waiting for an answer from Athena but unsurprisingly there's no response.

She’s been barricaded in her room for at least two days when she hears a quick tapping knock on her door—a knock only those Glimmer trusts the most know to use to signal who they are. She opens it, heart at her throat as she looks at who stands before her.

"Mother." Her boy stands tall, at least head higher than her. "The suitors are gone."

She pulls him inside, her eyes running over her son's frame. Glimmer doesn't have words for what her son means to her. She often thinks that if it hadn't been for him, she'd have drowned in despair long ago.

She lets her hands go onto his shoulders, looking him over for injury. She isn't stupid—she knows something has happened, screams echoing down the halls and weapons clanging. The sound and stench of death is inescapable. She doesn’t know what she'd do if her son was caught flat footed in the fray.

"Are you alright?" She can't imagine that her boy would have slain her suitors, not all of them.

"Yes." His smile is wide and his eyes are bright in a way Glimmer can’t recall seeing. "He's home." He blurts out.

Her heart stops again, hope and terror at wat inside her. "Who?"

"Father."

Any lingering questions fall into place. Bow is here. He likely killed the men who had been terrorizing her and her son for decades, making the palace safe again.

"Are you certain?"

He'd never seen his father before outside of the few portraits there are of Bow. If he's mistaken or if this is some trick, Glimmer doesn't know that she'll recover.

"Yes. I—he held me."

His voice quivers with tears and she wraps her arms around him like she did when he was a boy, constantly asking when he could see his father. Glimmer feels her knees buckle but she finds a way to stay standing.

All she can hear now is her heartbeat thrumming in her ears like a hummingbird. "Where is he?" She must see him. She needs to perceive him with her own sense, make sure it's the truth. When she sees Bow, she'll know.

"He asks me to tell you that he's here. He'll come for you."

Another promise. Hopefully it'll be easier to keep than the last. "Thank you."

Her son squeezes her tight for another moment and his smile turns indulgent. "No. Thank you for taking care of me."

"I don't know that I deserve that." The suitors have been a menace from when he was a babe on her hip. She remembers life before this, even if it's distant. Her son doesn't. Glimmer doesn't know what she should have done differently, but something in her feels that there must have been more she could have done for her boy.

"You do." He insists, brown eyes wide and hopeful. She thanks the gods every day that he somehow grew up to be as gentle and good as his father, even without never meeting him. "And now, we get to be a family." She holds back her tears, nodding at him. He lets her go, eyes and smile as warm as ever. "I'll let you wait for him."

She takes a sharp breath and she nods.

Waiting. She can do that.

She doesn’t have to wait long.

He approaches slowly, as if nearing an injured animal. Maybe that’s what she is now, her whole body trembling at the sight of him.

"Glimmer."

"You look different." She blurts out. "Thinner. And your smile—it didn’t look that way before."

The only word she can think of is he looks torn. His clothes are covered in blood, although he seems unharmed. She can imagine exactly how that happened.

She’s unphased by the blood and his gaunt frame. But Bow looks like someone grabbed all the pieces of him and made them jagged, trying to fit them together but they don't. Not anymore.

If possible, his smile looks even more pained as he meets her eyes. "It’s been a long time." His voice is gruff, but the timbre is unchanged.

She holds back a snort. What an understatement. "Is it really you? Or is this another dream again?"

She's tired of seeing figments of her imagination, of keeping the love she feels fed with the ghost of a whispered touch she might

feel in a delusional dream. Glimmer is so tired she can hardly stand it.

"I don’t know how to answer that. I'm not the man you knew before." His brown eyes are wet and his lip trembles. "I've done things I'm ashamed of. Things I can never undo."

She doesn’t care about that, as long as he’s real. "What have you done?"

"I've killed. Not in an honorable way. I’ve sacrificed my friends to my own goals and ends. My sister is a widow because of me." His eyes tighten. "The mercy, the kindness, the goodness in me—it's all gone. Dead. I had to give it up to make it back here, to stand before you again."

She doesn’t understand why he’s looking at her like that. Why he hasn’t kissed her yet. "Why are you telling me this?"

"I want you to know what I am before I ask anything of you."

"And what would you ask of me?"

"Do you think—" Tears streak his face now. "Would you love me again? Like this?" He holds his hands out, gesturing toward himself. "I’m not the man you called your husband anymore."

She’s not sure if the flames that lick at her blood are anger or disbelief. She’s waited a lifetime for him to make his way home, and he dares to say that he isn’t her husband? Dares to think that she might reject him for the very things that have brought him back to her?

Glimmer gives into her rage. She glances deeper into her room. "I have a favor to ask of you."

He takes a step forward. "Anything."

The desperate promise is almost enough to break Glimmer's resolve, but she needs to make her point. "Will you take this bed

out of my room? Toss it over your shoulder and make it as if it were never here."

The reaction is instant and exactly what she imagined. "Do you know what you're asking me to do?" Bow's jaw is clenched, outrage clear on his face, same as heartbreak. "I built this bed with my two hands out of the olive tree where we first met." He enunciates slowly as he gestures toward the ceilings and walls. "I built this palace around this bed. *Our* wedding bed. A symbol of our love. The only way to remove it from this room is to cut it out by its roots—to destroy it forever." He shakes his head. "Would you be so cruel as to ask this of me?"

"I wouldn’t be so cruel." She shakes her head. "But only my husband would know that. Only my husband, who used his blood and sweat to build us this bed and this home would know that this bed is rooted to the ground in this way, and all it means to the both of us. So, that means you must be him."

She takes a moment to enjoy the almost dumbfounded look on his face. It wasn't a common one for Bow although it's not the first time she's garnered it. She hopes it isn’t the last time either.

"I will fall in love with you over and over again." She promises, taking another step toward her husband. It’s an easy promise to make—as easy as breathing. "I don’t care what you've done—you're *mine*, Bow. You're my husband and I've been waiting for you." She can hardly choke out the next words as the knot in her throat grows bigger and she spreads her arms. "So will you just—come home?"

His face doesn't change, nothing changes for a few everlasting seconds. Finally, he runs into her open arms, holding her close. There's a loud sob and she’s not sure if it's from him or her—all she knows is that Bow's arms around her are real, the tears hot on her neck are real, the weight of him pressed against her is real.

"Glimmer." He sighs her name again, like a prayer. "Glimmer."

“I know.” She chokes back.

She imagined this reunion a million different times, in a thousand different iterations. But nothing is more important, more sacred, than that it finally happened. That she can be with Bow again.

His finger trails under her chin, tilting her face up. He leans down, lips barely brushing her own. Only a suggestion of a kiss.

“I love you.” They both sigh the words at the same time.

Bow chuckles softly, and it makes Glimmer lift onto her toes, pressing their lips together in earnest. It’s new but it’s the same as it’s always been. Bow’s lips are chapped and his hands frame her face, calluses rough on her cheeks.

When they break apart, she still stays close. “Never make me wait again.”

He wraps his arms around her tighter. “Never.” He swears, a new promise for him to keep between them.

End Notes

I really love EPIC: the musical and ever since I wrote the Catradora one shot, I know I wanted to finish up Glimbow's story. It's been reall great getting some time to write again. I hope you all enjoy it. Also, happy holidays!

Like the last one, the Greek mythology isn't accurate and it's inspired by EPIC: the musical.

Kudos and comments are the best. You can find me on Twitter, Bluesky, and Tumblr.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!